Burning forests will undermine corporate net-zero targets by 2027

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【メール原文】

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Fire, drought, and possibly a record El Niño are releasing carbon stored in forests faster than credit safeguards can offset, forcing companies to reassess forest-based climate targets.
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At the same time, stricter rules on credit integrity, lower-cost satellite monitoring, and new public funding vehicles such as the Tropical Forest Forever Facility (TFFF) are making forest outcomes easier to measure, price, and finance.
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Europe continues to set the pace for forestry regulation, but traceability and legality rules are spreading to the UK, Japan, and agricultural producer countries such as India and Indonesia.

Legacy forest credits are losing credibility. A 2026 study found that 44 REDD+ projects collectively overstated avoided deforestation by more than ten times, and the EU has banned offset-backed "carbon neutral" consumer claims under its Empowering Consumers for the Green Transition Directive. Buyer interest in forest credits remains strong, but only 6% of inquiries turn into deals, reflecting deep uncertainty about credit integrity. Companies should audit their REDD+ holdings, adjust how they describe forest credit purchases by presenting them as contributions to forest protection rather than offsets, and carefully document the basis for any forest-related claims.

Deforestation is also fueling a broader energy risk. Forest loss is the main driver of declining rainfall in the Amazon, and a strong El Niño will likely persist into early 2027. As a result, hydro-dependent grids in Brazil, the Congo Basin, and southern Africa face growing strain. In southern Africa, Lake Kariba's usable storage stood at just 11.83% in early 2026. Lower hydro output could force greater use of gas-fired power, weakening the clean-energy credentials that energy-intensive producers—miners, agribusinesses, and pulp mills—rely on to meet decarbonization targets.

There are also emerging opportunities. Article 6 crediting is moving from rulemaking to issuance, and the EU's 2040 climate target could create compliance demand for forest credits starting in 2036. Forest project sponsors should secure host-government authorization early, because authorized units will likely command a premium. Nature credit frameworks are also taking shape in the EU, Indonesia, and Vietnam. Companies that begin collecting robust biodiversity baseline data now will be better positioned if compliance-linked demand materializes.

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